

Else had told us how phosphorescence burning on human skin could not be put out, and how a seventeen-year-old soldier, weak from starvation, had been fed at a stranger mother's breast in the bunker before he returned to fight Russian soldiers in the final Breslau street battles. She had told us how a fat man had wedged himself into the shelter's entrance, and had been mown down by the hysterical mob. She had told us how she herself had carried her sick mother across a burning rooftop.

Beneath the reconstructed Novi Targ square, John identified shelters in two places, downstairs bolted against public entry. Plain and ugly high-rise public housing of cheap materials now stood around the bare square, where once interesting seventeenth-century merchant houses had stood amid a lively marketplace. People had lived in apartments even before the Communist-style transformations. Before their destruction, the old buildings of Breslau were of stately proportions, made of good material by experienced artisans who valued their talents and who took pride in a town with depth to its history.

Novi Targ now looks much sadder and more neglected than my glossy photos show. Breslau's lively markets that were once a feature of the city, as shown in my photographs of 1905, were relocated by the council in the second half of the twentieth century to a large new market hall. This was allegedly because of the congestion caused in the city's central squares by traders with their cars, animals and stalls.

I was nevertheless deeply moved. This ugly restoration was on ground where my grandmother and her children had walked so many times. Grandmother Emma and my beloved aunt Else had lived there for fifteen years before 1945. My mother had corresponded with them from far away.

Had we stayed longer, we would have enjoyed other moments of pleasure in a city that remains drab, and in which not even the theatre has been restored. The original buildings, and what they stood for, were German. The culture of Silesia before 1945 has not yet been generally acknowledged. It is also part of Polish history. I am sure this will change.